BOOKS

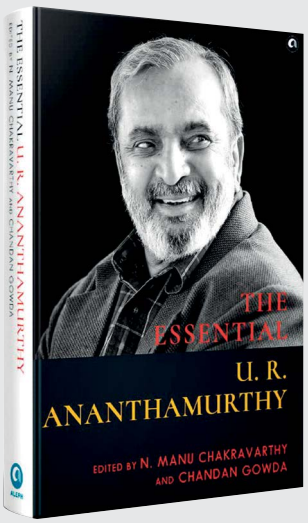
MARXISM WITH MYSTICISM

U.R. Ananthamurthy, as this new anthology reveals, straddled tradition and modernity with ease

U.R. Ananthamurthy (1932-2014) was a promising young academic working for his PhD in England, on leftist English fiction, when he pushed aside his dissertation to begin writing a novel—in his mother-tongue Kannada. Set largely inside an *agrahara* (i.e., an ultra-orthodox Brahmin neighbourhood), the novel radically interrogated the hollow but still hallowed practices concerning sin, sex, untouchability and death rites.

Translated by A.K. Ramanujan under the original title *Samskara* (1965), the novel was instantly acclaimed as a classic of modern Indian literature. Ananthamurthy went on to write all his creative works in Kannada, while he deployed his perfect bilingualism in many of his essays written in English. Even more effectively, he delivered in English unscripted lectures of astonishing originality and felicity. When he was invited to deliver the Radhakrishnan memorial lectures at Oxford, he maintained this *vachik parampara*, the oral tradition. As he explained to an incredulous friend, "I trusted God"!

In fact, Ananthamurthy was a lifelong secular socialist who fought against superstition and discrimination of all kinds. And yet, like his great mentor Ram Manohar Lohia, he appreciated the value of the indigenous. He was not a knee-jerk denouncer of tradition, especially in contexts where a blind imitation of the West passes for modernity.



THE ESSENTIAL U.R. ANANTHAMURTHY
Edited by N. Manu Chakravarthy and Chandan Gowda
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Thus, he once boldly defended, or at least ambivalently debated, the custom of Dalit women offering worship in the nude at a particular shrine in Karnataka, and confessed, "My dream of combining Marxism with mysticism in actual praxis will never come true". And yet, he dreamt on. His last work, completed weeks before his death, was *Hindutva or Hind Swaraj?* (2014), in which he pitted Gandhi's seminal tract denouncing western modernity against the forces of obscurantist reaction.

These fervent intricacies of Ananthamurthy's deep thinking and deeper feelings are well reflected in the new anthology of his works under review, edited by N. Manu Chakravarthy and Chandan Gowda, who were both among his young interlocutors. Their selection begins with a crisp informative introduction and ends with a candid interview with one of the editors, Gowda.

In between come short extracts from his four novels, including an incandescent scene from the second novel, *Bharathipura* (1996), in which an atheist liberal wants the shudras to touch a 'saligram', a small black stone worshipped as God. But they shrink from it, and him, until he shouts at them with "sheer violence" and coerces them into doing so.

The six longish short stories, reprinted in full, do finer justice to Ananthamurthy's narrative art. His memoirs include a reflective account of his marriage to a lively Christian student in anguished defiance of his parents' wishes. These memoirs are titled 'Suragi', a title not explained here. It is the name of a flower whose fragrance lingers long after it has withered, an apt metaphor for Ananthamurthy's enduring posthumous fame. ■

Harish Trivedi